



Stuck in a rut: Multiple ISL clubs had put first-team operations on hold over the last nine months, with their day-to-day functioning grinding to a halt. AIFF MEDIA

clubs to restart operations, complete transfers and get venues ready. Kerala Blasters, Mumbai City FC, Jamshedpur FC and even newly promoted Inter Kashi, among others, have made multiple signings, including foreign recruits, and look set for four months of regular football.

The league will, however, have some major overseas players absent. Blasters captain Adrian Luna and last season's highest goalscorer Alaaeddine Ajaraie have been loaned out, while two-time ISL winner Tiri moved on from Mumbai City amid the league's uncertainty.

On the flip side, Antonio Lopez Habas, the ISL's most successful head coach (2 Cups, 1 Shield), returns to the league after winning the I-League with Inter Kashi last season.

The campaign could also potentially be the last in professional football for Chhetri, one of the greatest servants of the beautiful game in India for over two decades.

For the ISL, light at the end of the tunnel is here, and players will finally walk out on February 14, a moment when the league begins its long climb back to the top, one match at a time.

